18.8 Summary

- AI agents introduce a new authorization challenge because they dynamically plan actions and interact with many systems during execution.
- Authentication alone cannot govern agent behavior because it verifies identity but does not constrain what actions an agent may attempt.
- Policy-aware agent loops integrate authorization directly into the agent's planning and execution cycle, ensuring that each action is evaluated against policy at runtime.
- Policies can serve not only as enforcement gates but also as constraint systems that guide agent planning using techniques such as Cedar's typed partial evaluation.
- Separating operational actions from control-plane operations helps protect the systems that define workflows, infrastructure, and authorization rules.
- Delegation allows agents to distribute work among specialized subagents while policies ensure that delegated authority remains within defined limits.
- Cross-domain delegation requires additional mechanisms—policies, promises, credentials, and reputation—to enable cooperation between independent systems.
- Verifiable credentials can transport delegated authority across organizational boundaries while local policies still determine whether specific actions are permitted.
- A society of agents emerges when independent systems interact under shared agreements, using policies to enforce behavior, promises to communicate intent, and reputation to evaluate past outcomes.